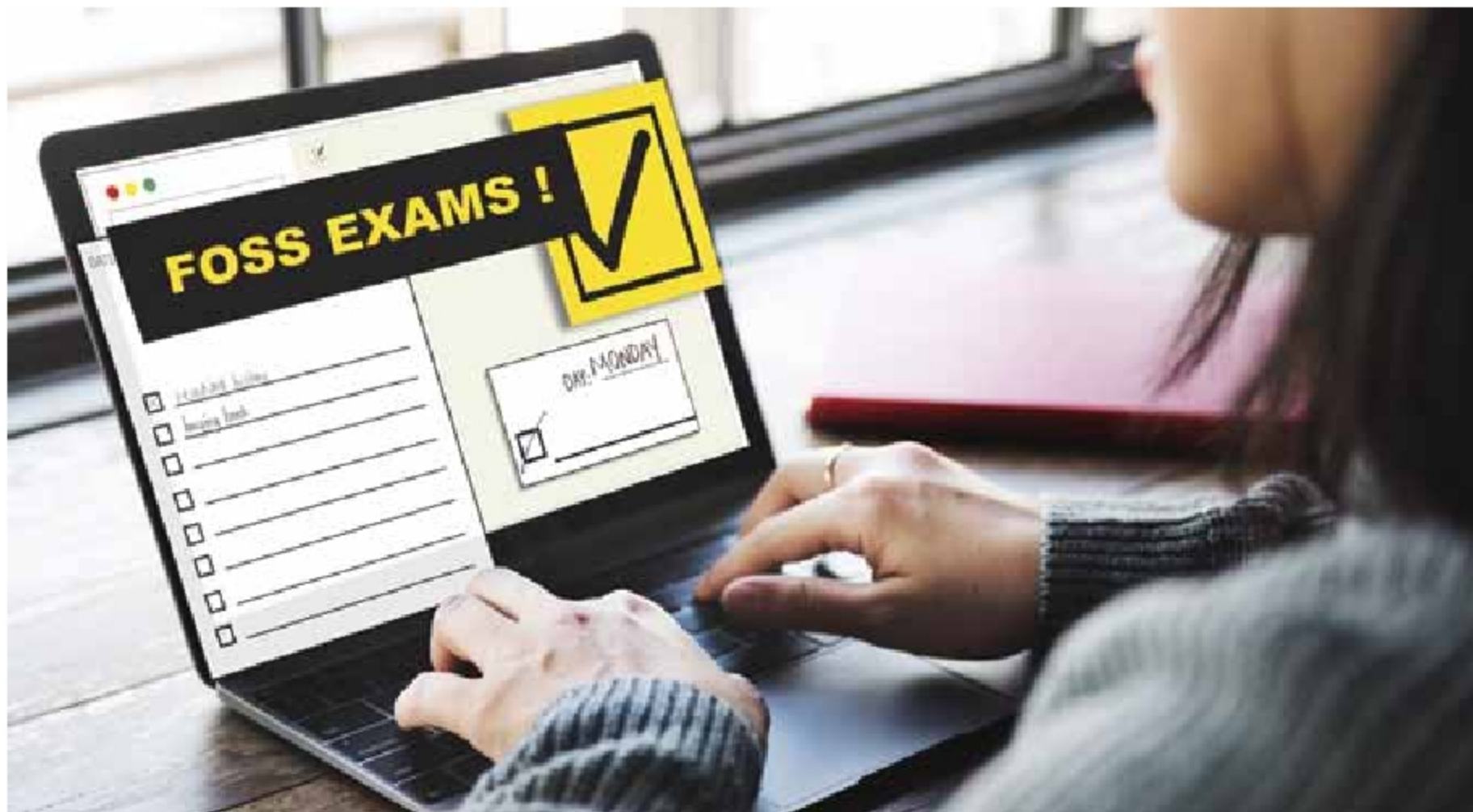


The Linux Professional Institute: Taking FOSS Exams to the World

Evan Leibovitch is the director of community relations for the Linux Professional Institute, an organisation he helped found two decades ago “to support the growth of open source.” The institute has conducted half a million exams across the world since then.



I'd heard about the Linux Professional Institute (LPI) ages ago, and was glad that my path crossed with that of its co-founder, Evan Leibovitch. What made me happier was when Leibovitch took out a small Tux, the yellow and black penguin that has long been the FOSS mascot, and presented it to me when we met against the backdrop of the Creative Commons 2019 Summit in Lisbon recently.

On the LPI's board are other big names like Jon 'Maddog' Hall, a programmer since 1969, who's worked on UNIX since 1980 and on GNU/Linux since 1994; and others like Bdale Garbee, a contributor to free software since 1979, as well as being a big time Debian contributor.

These stalwarts seek to achieve their goal by “helping people get work in Linux and advance themselves in it” — in other words, by advancing professionalism in the operating system (OS).

“For most of the 20 years that the LPI has been around, we've been doing skills certifications based on jobs. So if an employer doesn't know anything about the OS, but needs a third party to verify somebody's skills, then this certification is the way to do it,” explains Leibovitch.

Here are some stats about this pioneering institute — sources at the LPI say it has conducted half-a-million exams over the past 20 years. In over 180 countries worldwide, there is at

least one LPI certified person, and exams are held in seven languages. “If we were able to determine that there was enough demand for this in Hindi, we'd do the exams in Hindi,” Leibovitch says. The institute claims to thrive on international work. Leibovitch says the certifications are respected by employers and academic institutions, globally.

Says Leibovitch, “We're not the only ones offering certifications out there. Red Hat is also doing skills certification. We are headquartered in Canada but operate globally. We work with a social mission to improve the OS by improving the people who work with it.” Certification, he says, is not an end in itself; what's important is how you get there.